

Book Review by Dennis Gahm:

A Plain Account of Christian Perfection by John Wesley

- “impossibility of being half a Christian” (4)
 - So, what is Christian Perfectionism? If I am correct, it means that we can be perfect and completely sanctified in Christ in this lifetime.
 - Our goal in life is to become sanctified. Why do we sin? Why do we get angry? Why do we have habits that destroy? It is because there is unresolved guilt, or something that hasn’t been fully healed in us.
 - But Wesley believed that a mature Christian can reach the point of becoming fully sanctified and Perfect.
 - Jesus commands us, “Be perfect as your heavenly Father is perfect.” Why would he command this if it is impossible for us to be perfect?
 - Maybe this is the standard and we are to simply try to aim toward it, even though we may fall short?
 - **This is where the debate lies.**
 - Wesley says here, it is impossible to be “half a Christian.” Is a Christian always Perfect? Can he have flaws?
 - Romans 7 shows a man who carries with him a “body of death,” and does “what he does not want to do.” That surely is not a Perfect Christian? But is that the depiction of a man before he is saved – before he is a Perfect Christian or a Christian at all? Or is Romans 7 a depiction of a flawed Christian – the Christian that we are all too familiar with?
- Dennis’ opinion
 - Now, I think that we all have sin.
 - Sin, is not necessarily guilt.
 - I guess it is just a matter of defining things.
 - But what I mean is that there are negative things in our lives – certain thoughts, temptations, or evil things in our minds or hearts. And this is the case with Jesus as well, I believe, before he was resurrected. Jesus had to fight all these temptations and evils. But Scripture says he was perfect.
 - Giving in to these temptations and acting out these evils and making the evil thought a real thing in reality – this is sin and evil and bad. This is not perfect. Jesus did not do this.

- But it's a fine line between what is evil and what is simply attacking.
- Is sentencing a man to prison for his evils, an evil? Is yelling at a monster who is stealing candy, an evil? Is losing control and getting angry, an evil?
- Is all the sins you committed actually something out of your control and is sin acting out and not actually you doing it? Therefore, you are perfect, and it is sin doing this? That is the argument of Romans 7 – that sin is the one doing the action, not actually us. Therefore, in Romans 8, it says, "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those of us in Christ Jesus," because we are innocent – we may actually be perfect.
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